

Boston Sunday Globe

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New lead on cancer rise amid the young

Local scientists studying link to processed foods

By Marin Wolf
GLOBE STAFF

Claudia Umanita’s stomach pain started slowly in 2024, the kind of dull cramping that could have come from myriad common causes: constipation, her menstrual cycle, a virus. But stomachaches tend to dissipate, and this one just wouldn’t.

No one said the big, scary word, at least at first. Cancer, after all, seemed unlikely. Umanita was young — 21, enjoying her summer break before her junior year at University of Massachusetts Amherst. And when doctors found a mass in her colon, they thought it could be a polyp or a cyst, something the surgeon at Massachusetts General Hospital could easily remove.

Umanita woke from surgery to find an ostomy bag taped to her left side; the mass was too large to remove from her large intestine, the surgeon explained.

Two weeks after the first twinge of pain in her belly, doctors diagnosed Umanita with colon cancer. It granted

CANCER, Page A13

The Globe salutes the finest high school athletes of the fall season in the **All-Scholastics** section inside.

Thousands of people marched in Minneapolis and elsewhere, including Boston, to protest the fatal shooting of a woman by a federal immigration officer in Minnesota and the shooting of two people in Portland, Ore. **A6, B1-2.**

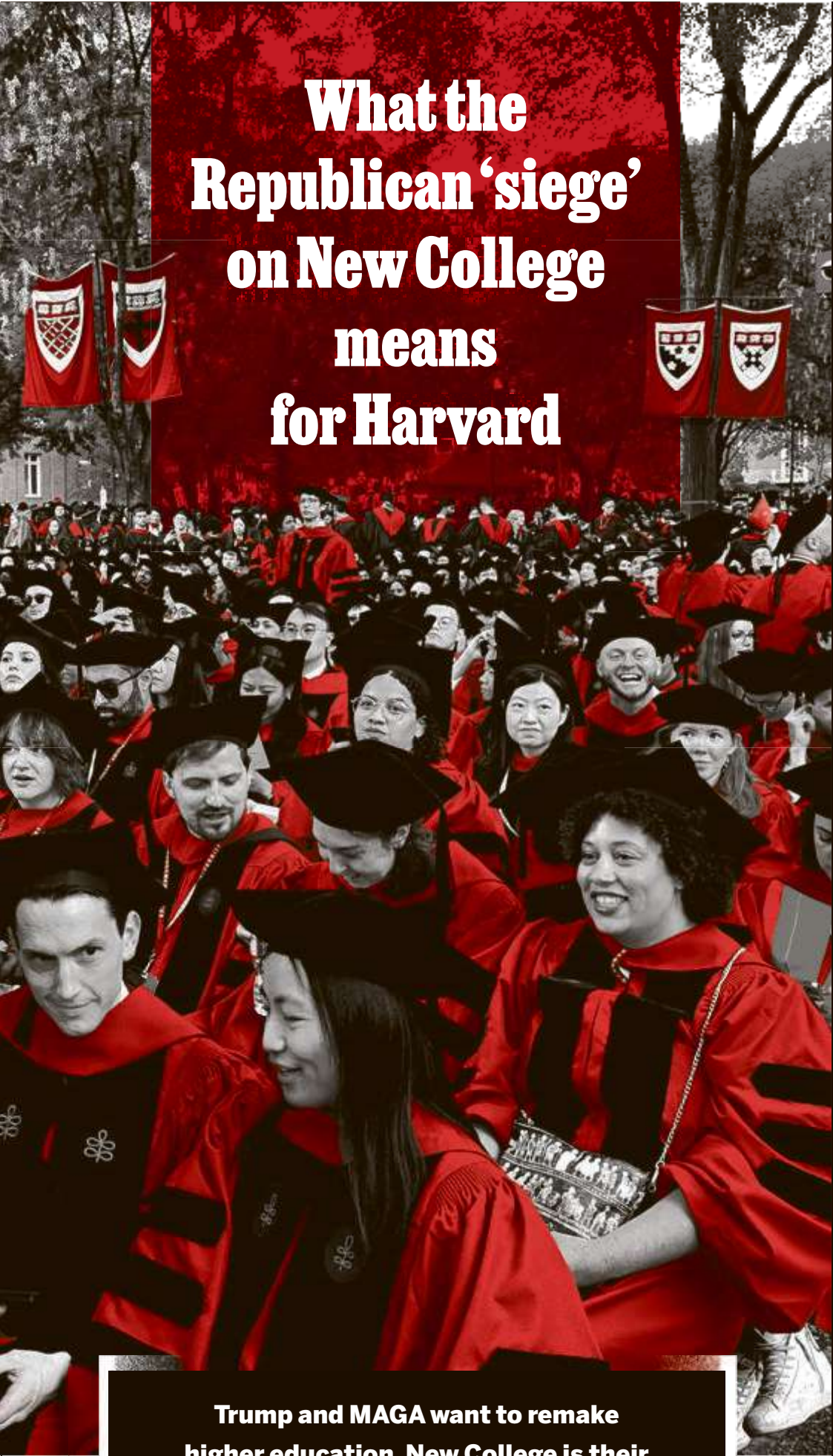
For professional ballet dancers, pursuing motherhood can still feel uniquely risky. But now more dancers like Boston Ballet’s Chenxin Liu are feeling supported. **SundayArts, N1.**



Cloud pleaser

Sunday: Rain, then clouds. High: 41-46. Low: 26-31.
Monday: Partly sunny. High: 37-42. Low: 30-35.
Sunrise: 7:12 Sunset: 4:32
Complete report, **A24.**
Deaths, **A18-23.**

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What the Republican ‘siege’ on New College means for Harvard

Trump and MAGA want to remake higher education. New College is their blueprint for how to do it.

Third in a three-part series reported by Hilary Burns, Mike Damiano, and Patricia Wen. Today’s story is by Burns.

Folded into an Adirondack chair too small for his 6 foot, 6 inch frame, Jackson Dawson gazed across Sarasota Bay, a century-old marble mansion at his back. Life at New College of Florida has been good to him.

Dawson, a junior at the small liberal arts school run by the state, was recently recognized as a “star student” on New College’s Instagram page. He plays on the varsity basketball and golf teams and started the college’s chapter of Turning Point USA, the late Charlie Kirk’s national movement for college conservatives. New College recently said it would commission a statue of Kirk to stand on campus in honor of free speech.

Smart, athletic, and civically engaged, Dawson was an in-demand applicant at many colleges. Harvard University recruited him to play football, and he enjoyed a campus visit to Cambridge. But he ended up choosing New College because it was close to family, he liked

the academic offerings, and it awarded him an academic scholarship.

He’s been pleased with his decision. Earlier this year, Dawson interned as a special assistant to Kristi Noem at the Department of Homeland Security. He “had some power” to review government contracts, or “even cancel them,” he said. “Whatever I felt was best for the American people.” He expects to graduate in the spring, a year early, and hopes to one day work in politics.

Dawson, one of roughly 870 undergraduates on this 110-acre campus under the Florida sun, finds New College comfortable. He points to brand new sports fields a quick walk from that marble mansion, which is now used for administrative offices and was originally owned by Charles Ringling of the circus family. A newly renovated campus coffee shop sells lattes and acai bowls.

He’s also comfortable sharing his conservative beliefs in class, which he’s heard hasn’t always been the case at liberal institutions like Harvard. “At most schools, if you believe one

HARVARD, Page A14

Harvard graduates gathered for commencement ceremonies on May 29, 2025.

RICK FRIEDMAN/AFP VIA GETTY IMAGES

Biotechs hope long bad spell at an end

Optimism among Mass. firms as deals pick up

By Marin Wolf
GLOBE STAFF

After holding its breath for several rough years, Greater Boston’s life sciences sector is cautiously coming up for air.

The biotech industry has struggled since an investment bubble from the pandemic era burst in 2022. And then it took blow after blow in the months since President Trump took office, from tariffs to drug pricing changes to cuts to early stage research that threaten to rupture the industry’s pipeline of new drugs. Deals stagnated. Pandemic-era successes such as Moderna made substantial layoffs amid rising vaccine skepticism. Scientists scrambled to find money to keep their research alive.

It was a year of devastating uncertainty for the sector and its roughly 75,000 Massachusetts employees. But entering 2026, which kicks off for the industry with the annual J.P. Morgan Healthcare Conference in San Francisco on Monday, biotech leaders and analysts say companies have a better understanding of the new financial and regulatory landscape, and

BIOTECH, Page A13

Vrabel’s bond began with off-field teamwork

By Nicole Yang
GLOBE STAFF

FOXBOROUGH — Patriots corner-back Carlton Davis was initially skeptical when he learned of the team’s agenda one day this past spring.

“In the moment, I’m like, ‘What are we doing?’” Davis recalled.

Coach Mike Vrabel had decided to pair each player with a partner outside of his position group, asking the two to collaborate on an activity reminiscent of a challenge from the longtime reality show “Survivor.” One player was blindfolded, while the other attempted to guide them through an obstacle course using only verbal instructions.

Davis, an eight-year NFL veteran, had never done such an exercise. Neither had his partner, wide receiver DeMario Douglas.

Despite his hesitation, Davis participated and did his best to listen to his teammate’s directions.

PATRIOTS, Page C10



DANIELLE PARHIZKARAN/GLOBE STAFF/FILE
Coach Mike Vrabel celebrated with running back TreVeyon Henderson.

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